1.4 Pioneers and Native Americans

Most people don't enjoy doing chores, even with the help of modern conveniences. Imagine how hard it was for families traveling along the Oregon Trail in the 1840s to prepare meals or wash clothes while also coping with illness and injuries in unfamiliar territory.

MAIN IDEA Pioneers who moved west endured hardships, and their encounters with Native Americans had profound effects on both cultures.

A DIFFICULT JOURNEY

Pioneers heading west usually traveled in groups of covered wagons called **wagon trains**. No matter the destination, the journey was grueling and took several months. Wagon trains crossed rivers and mountains as well as arid lands where water and vegetation were scarce. The long days demanded difficult chores and wearying travel.

Pioneers dealt with severe weather, including sandstorms, snowstorms, and floods. They also fought diseases such as cholera and typhoid. Because of the long distances between outposts, or settlements, running out of food, water, and supplies was a constant worry.

Pioneer women performed tasks such as cooking and cleaning. They also worked alongside men—tending to livestock, gathering supplies, and repairing tools and wagons. Everyone pitched in, no matter who they were or what job needed to be done.

Life on the frontier wagon trains changed conventional gender roles. Excerpts from men's and women's diaries and letters capture both the hope and excitement of seeing new lands, the day-to-day tasks they had to do, and the great losses and hardships endured on the trail. The journal entries below, of a man and a girl, describe very different pioneer experiences.

PRIMARY SOURCES

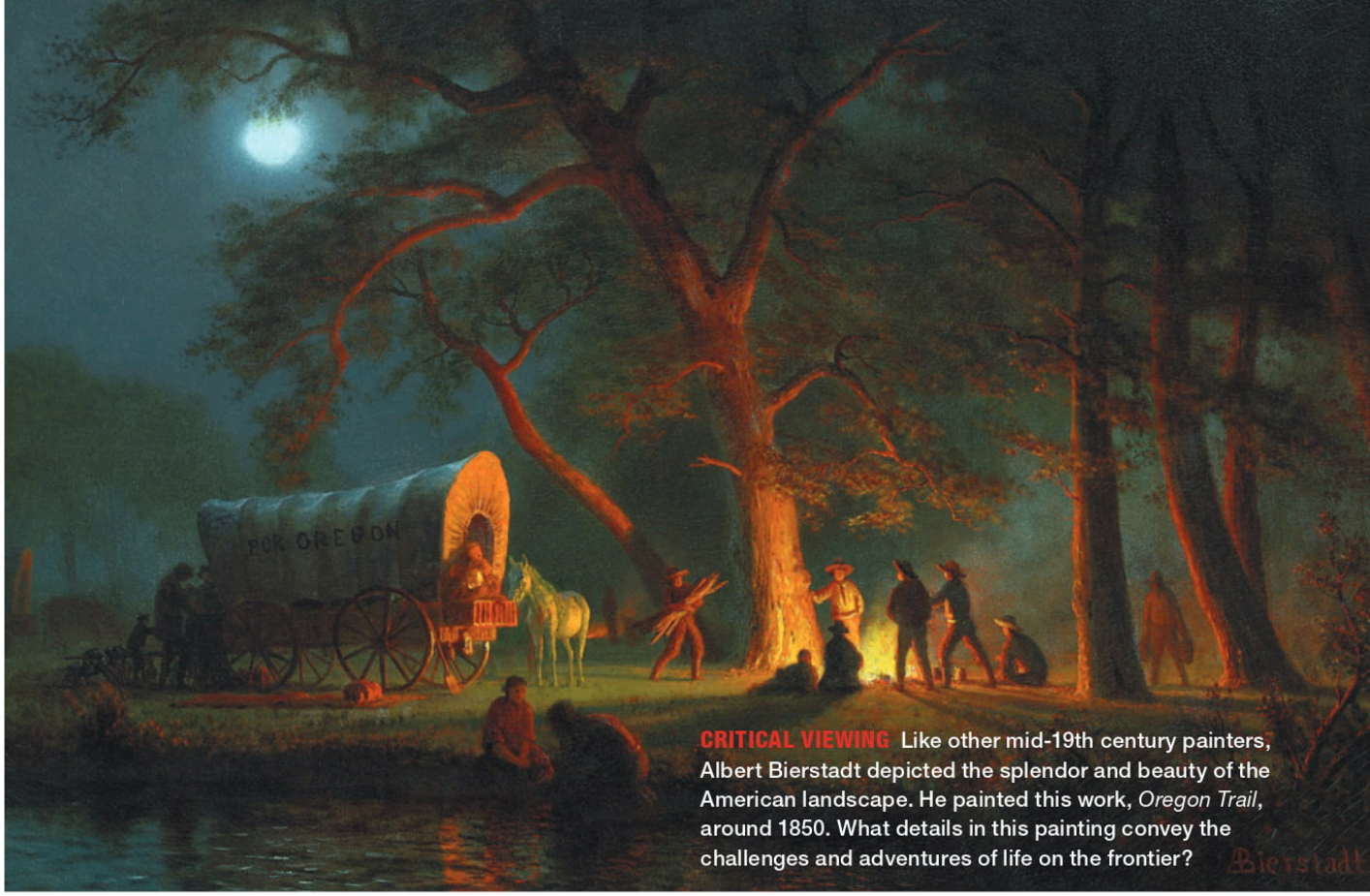
Today we met a large company, homeward bound. Some of our company purchased two milk cows from them. They say we never can get through, because there is no grass ahead, and the cholera is getting worse. Their wagons are crowded with sick men. Now our hearts began to fail us again and when we reflect that we have hardly made an introduction to our journey, the task becomes harder and we almost get weary of life.

—from "Journal of John Wood," by John Wood, 1852

One pleasant evening some Indian boys wanted to display their skill with bow and arrow. When we gave them a biscuit they would set it up, step off some distance and pierce it with an arrow. Father got a pan of biscuits and he would measure off a distance, set up one and tell them to shoot at it. The one who struck it first got it for his own. They had considerable sport over the biscuits.

—from *One Woman's West*, by Martha Gay Masterson, 1892

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CRITICAL VIEWING Like other mid-19th century painters, Albert Bierstadt depicted the splendor and beauty of the American landscape. He painted this work, *Oregon Trail*, around 1850. What details in this painting convey the challenges and adventures of life on the frontier?

CULTURAL ENCOUNTERS

Westward trails passed through lands inhabited by various Native American tribes. On the Great Plains, pioneers encountered the **Lakota**, and in the Oregon Territory they met the **Nez Perce**. Traders who traveled the Santa Fe Trail to the New Mexico territory interacted with southwestern tribes such as the **Zuni**.

The Lakota, Nez Perce, and Zuni had distinctive customs. Traditionally, the Lakota lived in tepees and hunted bison. The Nez Perce tended to settle along streams that provided a steady supply of food. Up to 30 families could live in one of their roomy lodges. The Zuni lived in adobe houses or dwellings built into cliffs.

Encountering Native Americans was a new experience for pioneers and for the people hearing about such encounters back home. In addition, works of fiction about westward journeys often exaggerated accounts of Native American attacks on pioneers. In reality, attacks were rare. Of the nearly 400,000 people who traveled the Oregon Trail in the mid-19th century, about 400 were killed in attacks by Native Americans. Most encounters were friendly, and Native Americans and settlers engaged in trade and sometimes helped each other.

Even so, as new settlers intruded on Native American land, conflicts did arise. In one instance, a cow wandered away from one of the pioneers traveling on the Oregon Trail, and was killed by a Native American. U.S. Army soldiers intervened by talking to the Native American chief. At first everyone behaved reasonably, but misunderstandings and a nervous soldier shooting his gun led to a battle near Fort Laramie, a U.S. military post in present-day Wyoming. By the time it ended, the Native American chief and 29 American soldiers had been killed in what is referred to as the Grattan Massacre of 1854.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** In general, what were interactions between pioneers and Native Americans like?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What kinds of challenges did pioneers heading west in wagon trains face?
3. **EVALUATE** What do we learn about family life on the frontier from the letters and diaries of travelers moving west?

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